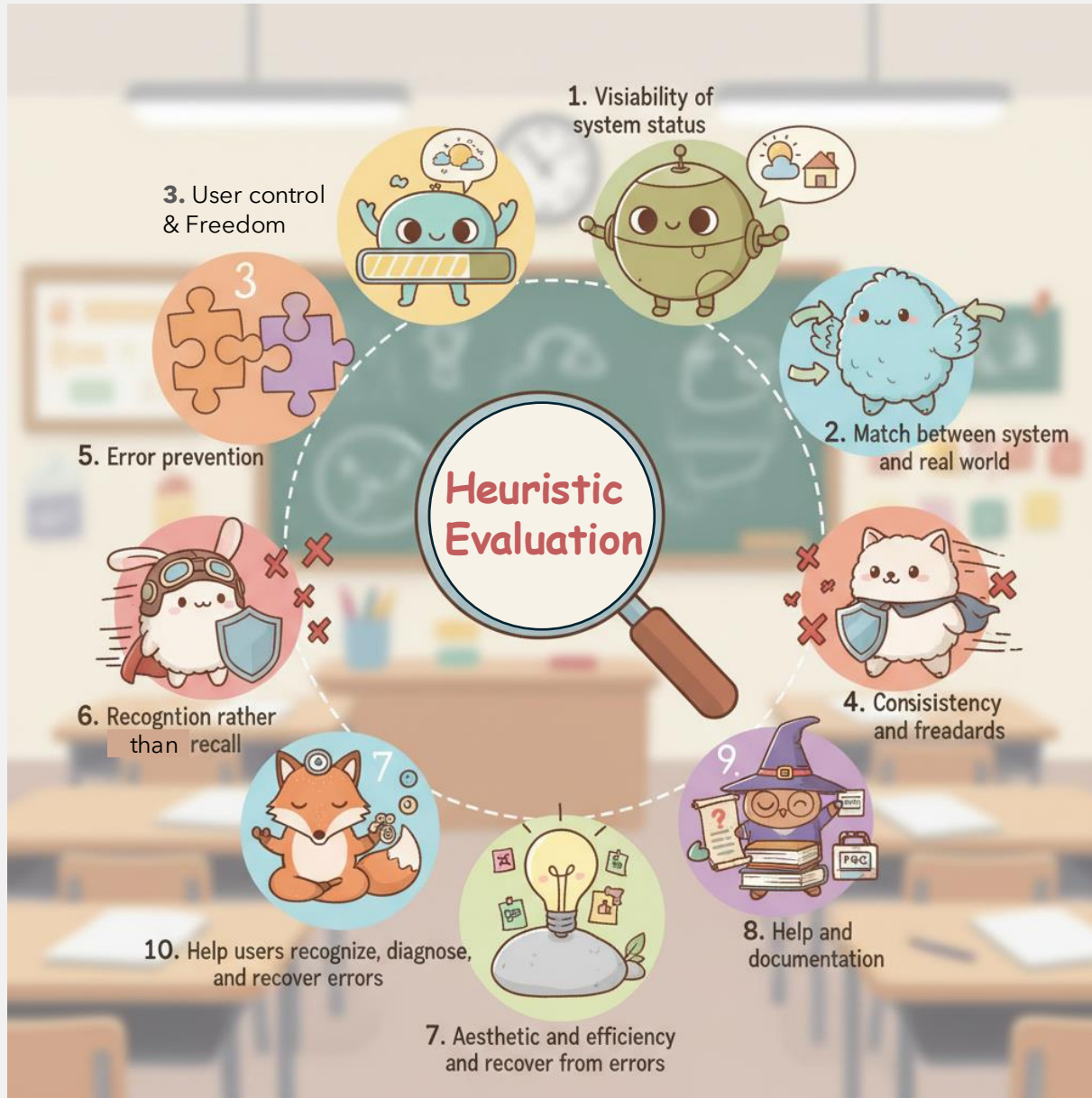


CSE472: HCI – Human Computer Interaction

Lecture – 20: Heuristic Evaluation Spring 2026



Inspiring Excellence



"Create a cute picture of hueristic evaluation of Nielsen's heuristics" [Perplexity]

Formal Usability Testing

Formal usability testing in a lab: cameras, one-way mirrors, etc.

Performed with participants representative of the target population

Pros:

- Reveals more problems than other methods
- Finds global problems
- Finds unique problems

Cons:

- Time-intensive / Expensive
- Does not detect minor problems well
- Target population may be difficult to find



Discount Usability Methods

Heuristic evaluation: Helps find usability problems in a design

- Term coined by Jakob Nielsen
- "Guerilla HCI" (1994) http://www.useit.com/papers/guerrilla_hci.html

Reaction to recommended usability engineering methods (expensive, intimidating)

10 principles

Small set (3-5) of evaluators examine interface

- independently check compliance with principles
- different evaluators will find different problems
- evaluators only communicate afterwards

Can be done on working interfaces or sketches

Nielsen's 10 heuristics (1994)

- Visibility of system status
- Match between system and the real world
- User control and freedom
- Consistency and standards
- Error prevention
- Recognition rather than recall
- Flexibility and efficiency of use
- Aesthetic and minimalist design
- Help recognize, diagnose, and recover from errors
- Help and documentation

1. Visibility

Visibility of system status

- The system should always keep users informed about what is going on, through appropriate feedback within reasonable time.

Refers to both visibility of system status and use of feedback.

- Anytime wondering what state the system is in, or the result of some action, this is a visibility violation.

1. Visibility

- Pay attention to response time
 - 0.1 sec: no special indicators needed
 - 1.0 sec: user tends to lose track of data
 - 10 sec: maximum duration if user to stay focused on action
 - longer delays absolutely require percent-done progress bars



Time Left: 00:00:19

searching database for matches



46%

2. Real World Match

- Match between system and the real world
- The system should speak the users' language, with words, phrases and concepts familiar to the user, rather than system-oriented terms. Follow real-world conventions, making information appear in a natural and logical order.
- Refers to word and language choice, conceptual model, metaphor, mapping, and sequencing.

2. Real World Match



"Mailto", "protocol"?

Match system to real world

- Speak the user's language

Mac desktop

- Dragging disk to trash should delete, not eject it

Match system to real world

- Speak the user's language
- Follow conventions



3. User Control and Freedom

- Users often choose system functions by mistake and will need a clearly marked “emergency exit” to leave the unwanted state without having to go through an extended dialogue.
- ***Support undo and redo***

3. User Control and Freedom



Don't force users down fixed paths

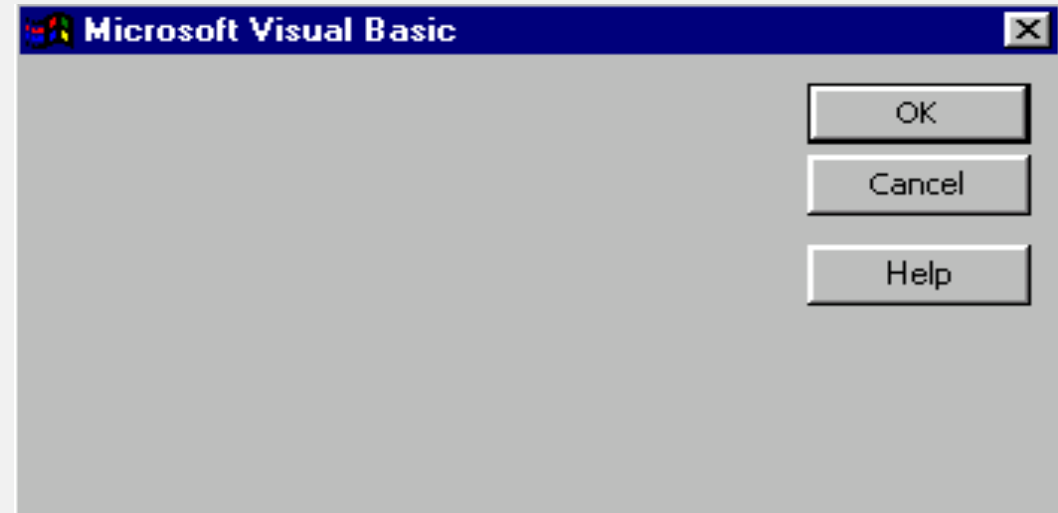
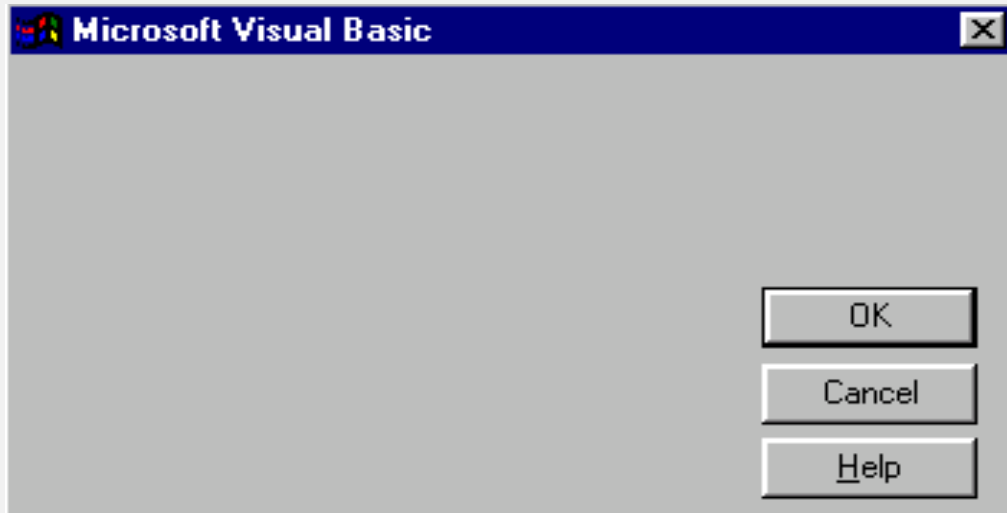
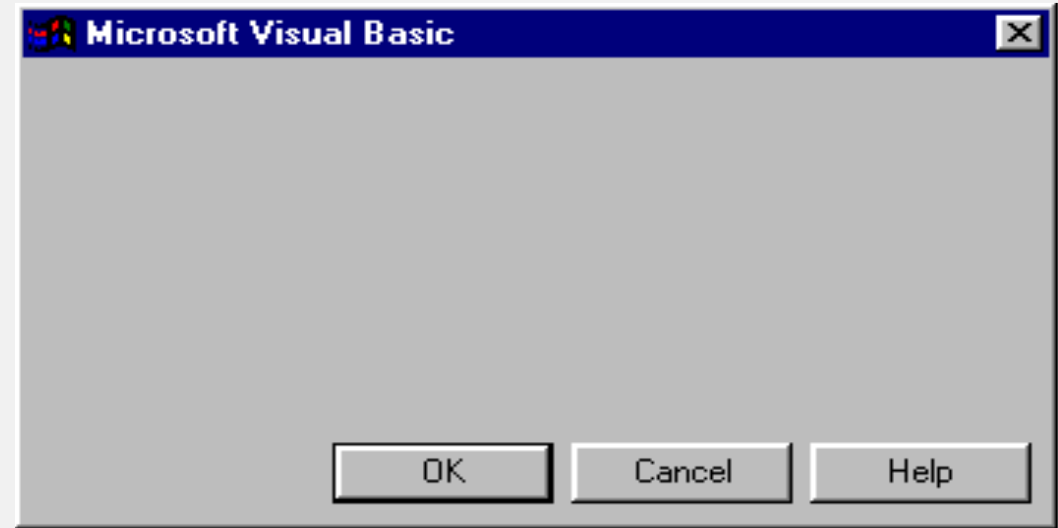
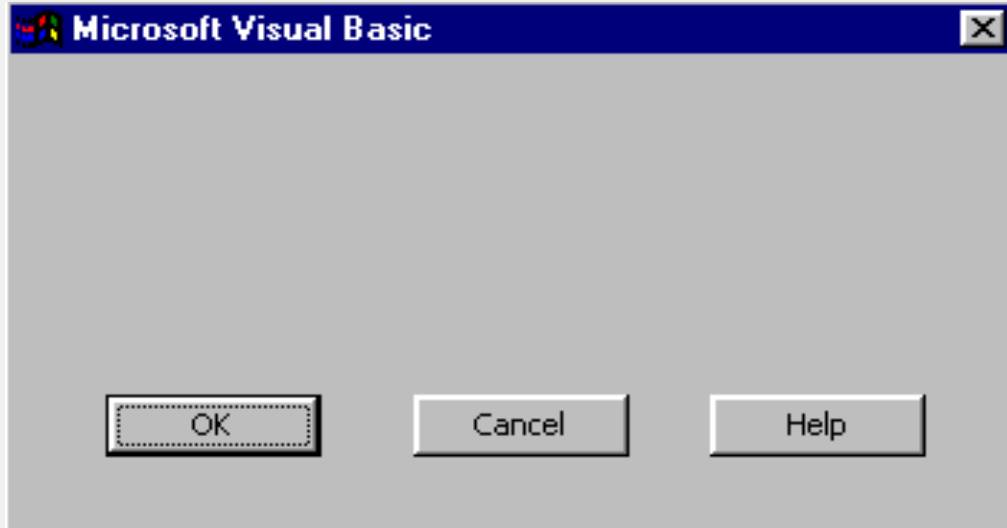
Wizards

- must respond to question before going to next
- good for beginners, infrequent tasks
- not for common tasks

4. Consistency and Standards

- Users should not have to wonder if different words, situations, or actions mean the same thing.
- Follow platform conventions.
- Internal consistency is consistency throughout the same product.
- External consistency is consistency with other products in its class.

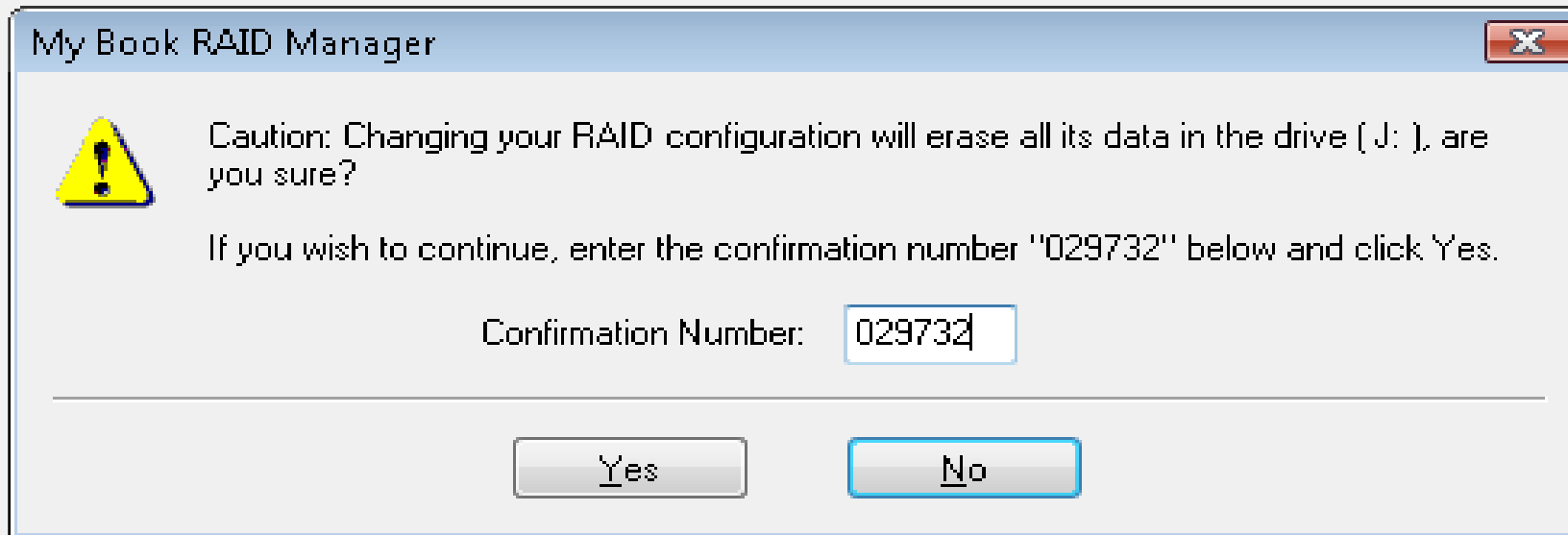
4. Consistency and Standards



5. Error Prevention

- Even better than good error messages is a careful design that prevents a problem from occurring in the first place.
- Either eliminate error-prone conditions or check for them and present users with a confirmation option before they commit to the action.
- Try to commit errors and see how they are handled. Could they have been prevented?

5. Error Prevention

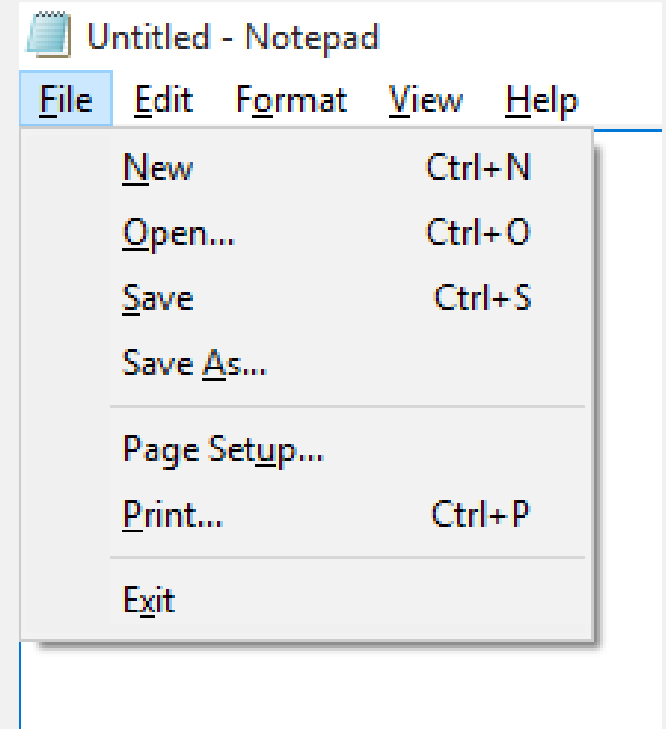


6. Recognition Not Recall

- People should never carry a memory load Obvious exception: passwords (but can be lessened...)
- Minimize the user's memory load by making objects, actions, and options visible.
- Instructions for use of the system should be visible or easily retrievable whenever appropriate.

7. Flexibility and Efficiency

- Cater to inexperienced and experienced users.
- Accelerators (e.g., keyboard shortcuts) may speed up interaction for expert users
- Allow users to tailor frequent actions (e.g., macros).
- Also allows multiple ways to do things.



8. Aesthetic and Minimalist Design

- Dialogues should not contain information which is irrelevant or rarely needed.
- Every extra unit of information competes with relevant units of information and diminishes their relative visibility.
- Not just about “ugliness” but about clutter, overload of visual field, visual noise, distracting animations, etc.

Form Title -- (appears above URL in most browsers and is used by WWW search engines)		Background Color:
Q&D Software Development Order Desk		FFFBF0
Form Heading -- (appears at top of Web page in bold type)		Text Color:
Q&D Software Development Order Desk		000080
E-Mail responses to (will not appear on Web page)	Alternate (for mailto forms only)	Background Graphic:
dversch@q-d.com		
Text to appear in Submit button	Text to appear in Reset button	☐ Mailto
Send Order	Clear Form	☒ CGI
Scrolling Status Bar Message (max length = 200 characters)		
WebMania 1.5b with Image Map Wizard is here!!		
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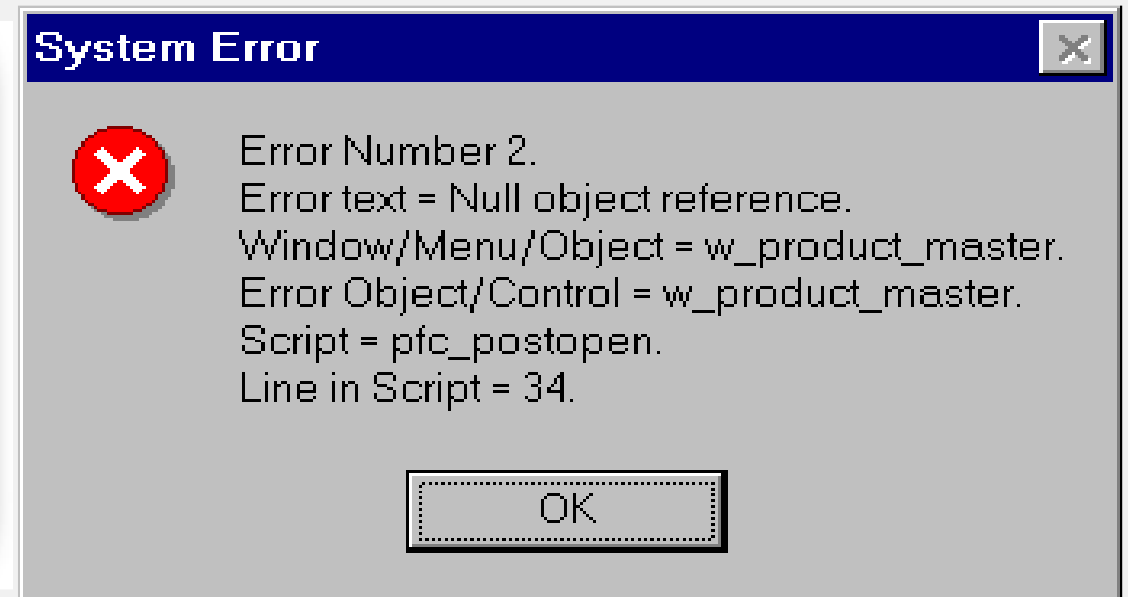
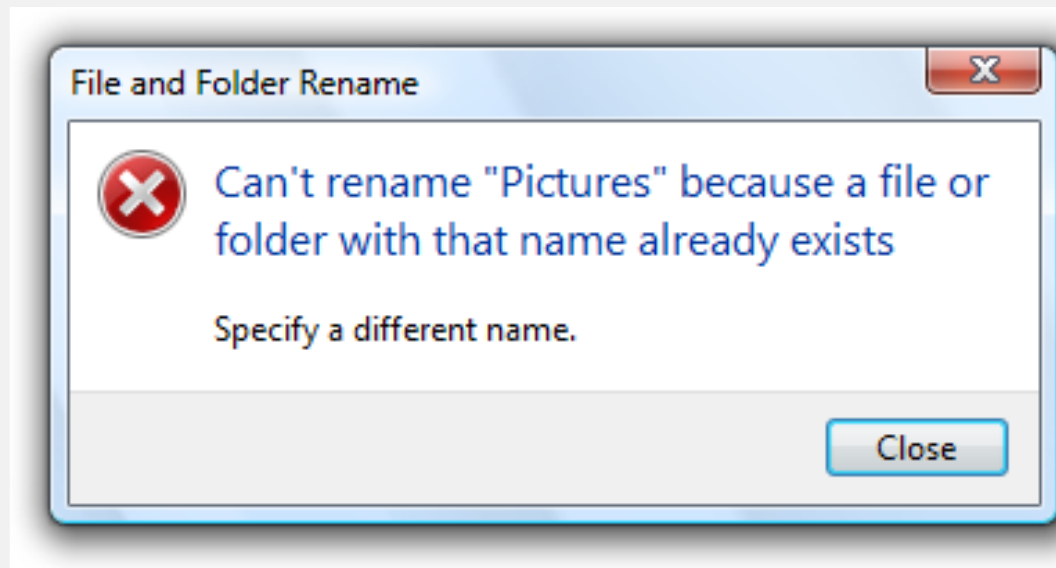
9. Error Recovery

Help users recognize, diagnose, and recover from errors

Error messages should be expressed in plain language (no codes)

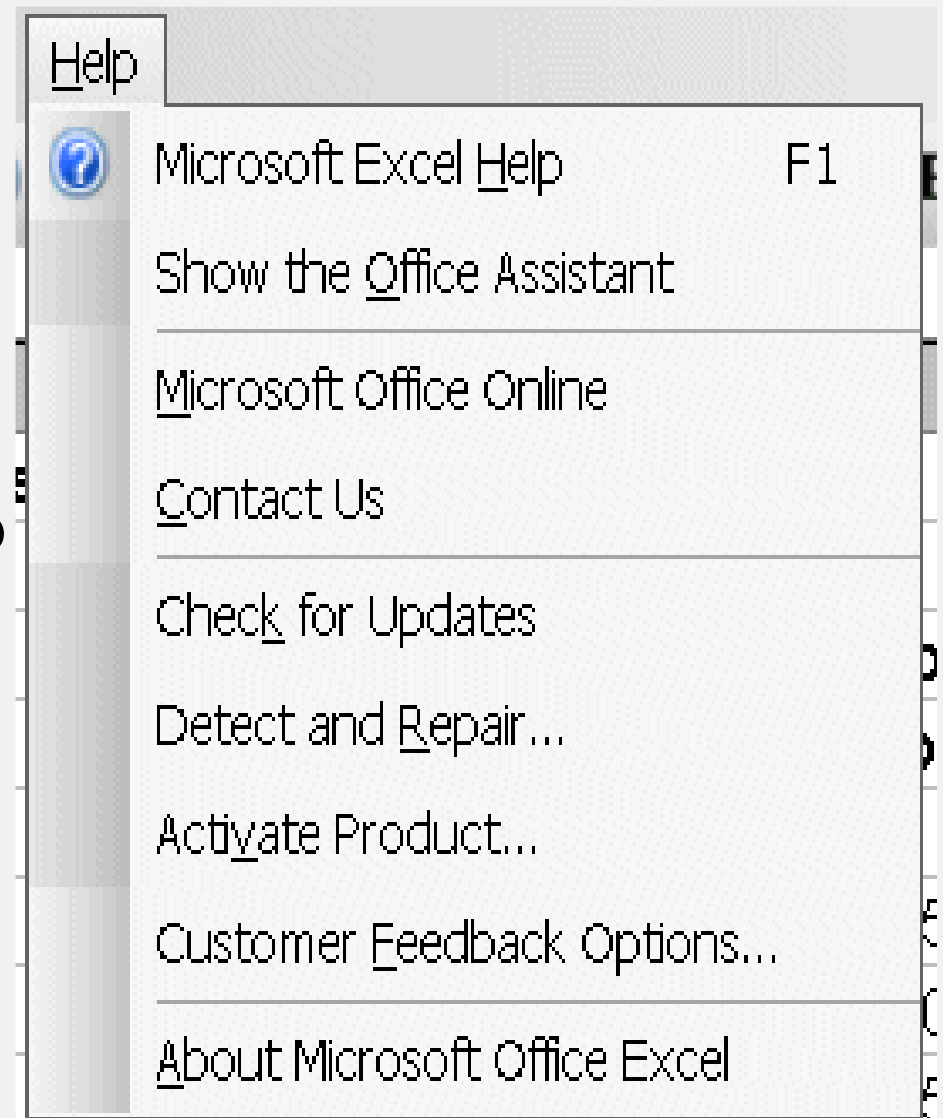
Precisely indicate the problem, and suggest a solution.

Error prevention (#5) is about preventing errors before they occur. This is about after they occur.



10. Help and Documentation

- Even though it is better if the system can be used without documentation, it is also often necessary to provide help and documentation.
- Any information should be easy to search, focused on the user's task, list concrete steps to be carried out, and not be too large.
- This does not mean that the user must be able to ask for help on every single item.



10 Heuristics

- Visibility of system status
- Match between system and the real world
- User control and freedom
- Consistency and standards
- Error prevention
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How to Perform Heuristic Evaluation

Evaluators go through interface several times

- inspect various dialogue elements
- compare with list of usability principles
- consider other principles/results that come to mind

Use violations to redesign/fix problems

Phases of Heuristic Evaluation

1. Pre-evaluation training

- give expert evaluators needed domain knowledge & information on the scenario

2. Evaluation

- individuals evaluate interface and make lists of problems

3. Severity rating

- determine how severe each problem is

4. Aggregation

- group meets and aggregates problems (w/ severity ratings)

5. Debriefing

- discuss the outcome with design team

How to Perform Heuristic Evaluation

At least two passes for each evaluator

- first to get feel for flow and scope of system
- second to focus on specific elements

If system is walk-up-and-use or evaluators are domain

- experts, no assistance needed
- otherwise might supply evaluators with scenarios

Each evaluator produces list of problems

- explain why with reference to heuristic or other information
- be specific & list each problem separately

Severity Rating

Used to allocate resources to fix problems

Combination of frequency, impact, persistence (one time or repeating)

Should be calculated after all evaluations are in

Should be done independently by all evaluators

Rating: 0 - don't agree that this is a usability problem

1 - cosmetic problem

2 - minor usability problem

3 - major usability problem; important to fix

4 - usability catastrophe; imperative to fix

Examples

[Consistency] [Severity 3: major usability problem; important to fix]

The interface used the string "Save" on the first screen for saving the user's file, but used the string "Write file" on the second screen. Users may be confused by this different terminology for the same function.

[Error prevention] [Severity 3: major usability problem; important to fix]

When the user clicks "delete" there is no dialogue asking them to confirm that this is what they really want to you. Users may accidentally delete their work.

[Aesthetic and minimalist design] [Severity 1: cosmetic problem]

The color used on the first screen is slightly different to the last screen. Users may notice the change and feel weird.

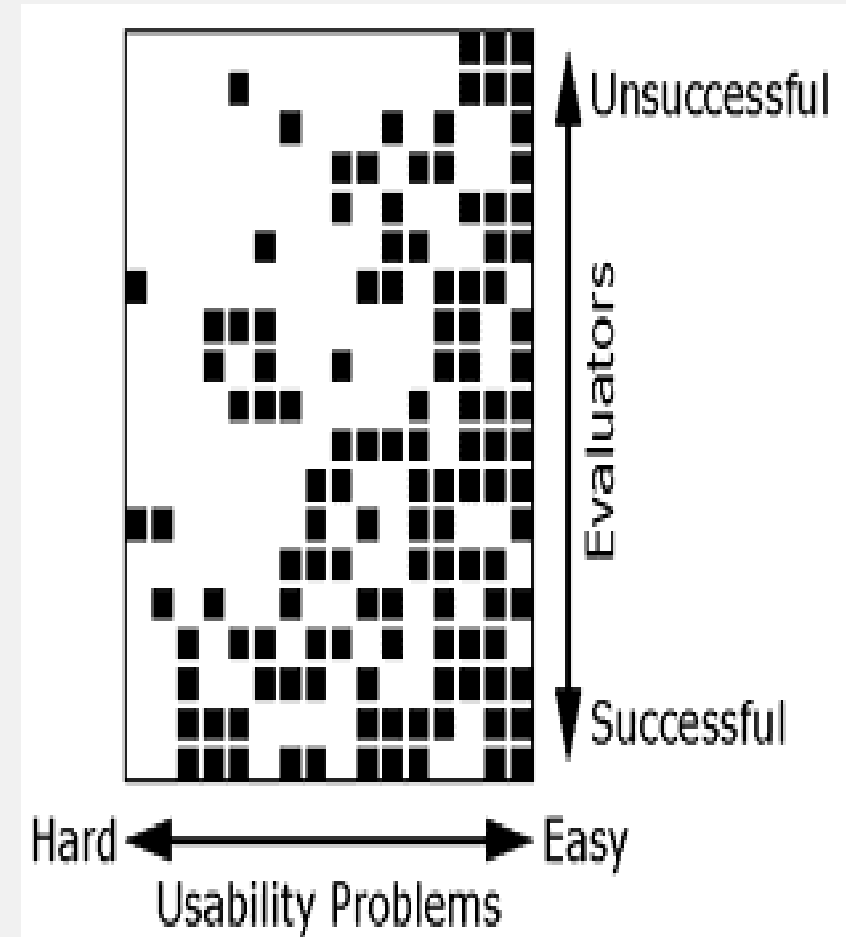
Why Multiple Evaluators?

Every evaluator doesn't find every problem

Good evaluators find both easy and hard problems

Single evaluator achieves poor results

- only finds 35% of usability problems
- 5 evaluators find ~ 75% of usability problems
- why not more???? 10? 20?
- adding evaluators costs more and won't find more problems



Debriefing

Conduct with evaluators, observers, and team members

Discuss general characteristics of interface

Suggest improvements to address major usability problems

Development team rates how hard to fix

Make it a brainstorming session

Heuristic Evaluation vs. Usability Testing

Heuristic evaluation is much faster

- 1-2 hours each evaluator vs. days-weeks

Heuristic evaluation doesn't require interpreting user's actions and is reasonably effective

- 1 expert 40% of errors, 2: 50%, 3: 60%, 5: 80%

User testing is more accurate (by definition)

- Takes into account actual users and tasks
- Heuristic Evaluation may miss problems & find "false positives"

Good to alternate between heuristic evaluation & user testing

- Find different problems
- Don't waste participant

Any Questions?